

Education of Potential

Between Potential and Ideal - split chapter

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Learning, distance, and understanding that is not a shortcut.

The problem education poses to the theory

Education is not merely a field in which one can say “there is potential.” It tests the theory itself: can a possibility be opened before a person without stealing the distance by which that possibility becomes theirs? A school, teacher, curriculum, exam, or AI tool is not only a medium of knowledge. It decides what appears before the learner, in what order, under what difficulty, with what support, and at what cost in shame, time, and trust.

The visible symptoms are grades, exams, homework, inequality, dropout, and performance anxiety. The deeper diagnosis is that education fails when it replaces formation with output. The output may look like knowledge, while the path by which knowledge becomes understanding has been stolen. The map of stolen path

Living understanding = learner potential × real question × practice × proper distance × trust × correction / fear × humiliation × shortcut × overload × empty measurement × indifference.

This is not a psychological formula. It is a relational map. It asks: how much help was given, how much attempt remained for the learner, whether the answer arrived before the question, whether difficulty still teaches or already erases, and whether the teacher or AI returns responsibility to the learner or takes it away.

A student submits work written by AI. Externally, there is an output. Internally, understanding may not have formed. The theory does not ask only whether this is cheating. It asks whether the tool removed the place where the question should have created the friction that becomes thought.

A teacher gives a hint instead of a full solution. This is slower in terms of efficiency, but optimal in the theory: near enough not to abandon, far enough not to steal. AI and the horizon of learning

Good AI in education is scaffolding, not a machine of answers. Good scaffolding holds and then withdraws. It expands the learner’s horizon of understanding without throwing the learner beyond it. When AI solves in the learner’s place, it produces a false optimum: fast output that behaves as if understanding has formed.

Education returns a precision to the theory: distance is not merely an obstacle; it is a condition of formation. But distance without accompaniment becomes erasure.